



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

does free
will explain
all evil?

One kind of example is what is sometimes called 'natural evil.' These are evils which do not seem to be caused by free will. Examples include the consequences of natural disasters like hurricanes and tsunamis, and the often terrible effects of disease.

1. The 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami is an evil.
2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the evil.
3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.
4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being.
(1,2,3)
5. If there is no omnipotent and perfectly good being, God does not exist.

C. God does not exist. (4,5)

Suppose that you think that all of these assumptions are true. That does not mean that we have a satisfactory treatment of the existence of evil from a theist perspective.

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good

the ability
to harm others
is a great good

That is because even if we might have an explanation of why there is some evil in the world, we do not yet have an explanation of why we find in the world the particular kinds of evils we do.

Let's take a particular example: the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami, which is estimated to have killed about 228,000 people. The following seems very plausible:

One line of response to this argument is to say that even though tsunamis are not caused by human free will, the evil they involve is.

THE ARGUMENT FROM NATURAL EVIL

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Summing up so far: we have seen that Frege will promise to explain how

God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

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**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

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The argument from natural evil

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